Television Poetry Program

By Todd Alcott, Shel Silverstein and Roald Dahl

Look at me. Look at me. Look at me, look at me.
Look at me. Look at me. No no no, don't look
over there, there's nothing over
there, look at me, look at me, look at me.
Are you looking at me? Is everybody looking at
me? Do I have your attention? Good.

INTRODUCTION

You invite him/her in and he insists on staying for dinner. After telling off-color jokes to your family, he/she shamelessly flirts with your spouse as he/she starts a sales pitch. You tell yourself that you will insist he/she show some of his/her better qualities on hi/hers next visit. His/Her name? Television. And while h/she may indeed have some redeeming characteristics, you might want to ponder your relationship with this compelling little device. A Television Poetry Program by Todd Alcott, Shel Silverstein and Roald Dahl.

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TELEVISION

Don't get me the wrong idea. I'm not trying to take over your life. You need, what? What do you need? You need to, what? Go to the bathroom? Fine. Get up, go to the bathroom, come back look at me. You need, what? You need to get something to eat? Fine. Get up, go to the kitchen, get something to eat, come back, look at me. You need to, what, sleep? Fine, get up, go to bed, go to sleep, get up, come back look at me.

Okay. So we have an agreement. You will do what you absolutely need to do, and when you're done, you will come back and look at me.

Don't worry about your schedule. I am here for you. I am here for you. Twenty-four hours a day, seven days a week, I am here for you.

I am here for you. You need me, I'm here. Fair and foul, thick and thin, I am here for you. I am here for you. People try to tell you I'm bad? You tell them that I am here for you.

Twenty-four hours a day, fair and foul, thick
and thin, I am here for you. I am here for you.
People try to tell you I'm bad, know what it
sounds like to me? Sour grapes.
You see what I - hey, hey, hey, hey, hey no, don't
look over there, there's nothing going on over
there, look at me, look at me, look at me.
I've got stuff you wouldn't believe. Danger? !@#$%^&?
Action? Death? Thrills? Comedy? All here, all
in the next eight minutes.
Can you believe it? You can't. It's unbelievable.
You can't believe it because it's unbelievable.
It's a miracle.
Just keep looking at me. Just keep looking at me.
Just keep looking at me. Look at me, look at
me, look at me, look at me, look at me

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Todd Alcott
Book: The Spoken Word Revolution
ISBN: 978-0321328953

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Publisher: Longman
Date(Month/Year): 2003

AWARD HISTORY

2004 National Qualifier

TRANSITION

Every year in April, an initiative (only somewhat successfully) sweeps the Nation: National TV-Turnoff Week! This annual event aims to give back what TV often takes away: our productivity, creativity, health, inter-personal relating, civic engagement, spiritual gift development and moral decency. In fact, studies have found that the average American child watches 1,197 minutes of TV each week while the average parent spends 38 minutes a week with their child in meaningful conversation. Something must be done . . . or our children may face the same fate as Jimmy Jet by Shel Silverstein.

Jimmy Jet and His TV Set

I'll tell you the story of Jimmy Jet --
And you know what I tell you is true.
He loved to watch his TV set
Almost as much as you.
He watched all day, he watched all night
Till he grew pale and lean,

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From "The Early Show" to "The Late Late Show"

And all the shows between.

He watched till his eyes were frozen wide,

And his bottom grew into his chair.

And his chin turned into a tuning dial,

And antennae grew out of his hair.

And his brains turned into TV tubes,

And his face to a TV screen.

And two knobs saying "VERT." and "HORIZ."

Grew where his ears had been.

And he grew a plug that looked like a tail

So we plugged in little Jim.

And now instead of him watching TV

We all sit around and watch him.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Shel Silverstein
Book: Where the Sidewalk Ends
ISBN: 978-0060586539
Publisher: HarperCollins
Date(Month/Year): January 2004

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TRANSITION

Mike Teavee, a character in the Roald Dahl's book Charlie and the Chocolate Factory *is particularly obsessed with television. He likes to act out gangster shootings and becomes very angry if anyone stops him from watching TV, his parents included. Sound familiar. Child psychologists repeatedly warn our society of the perils of too much TV – warnings that often fall on deaf ears. Perhaps the message would be better accepted if delivered via Oompa Loompa. Their words of wisdom from 1964 still ring true today! Oompa Loompa Doompa De Do – I've got final message for you . .*

Television

The most important thing we've learned,

So far as children are concerned,

Is never, NEVER, NEVER let

Them near your television set --

Or better still, just don't install

The idiotic thing at all.

In almost every house we've been,

We've watched them gaping at the screen.

They loll and slop and lounge about,

And stare until their eyes pop out.

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(Last week in someone's place we saw
A dozen eyeballs on the floor.)
They sit and stare and stare and sit
Until they're hypnotised by it,
Until they're absolutely drunk
With all that shocking ghastly junk.
Oh yes, we know it keeps them still,
They don't climb out the window sill,
They never fight or kick or punch,
They leave you free to cook the lunch
And wash the dishes in the sink --
But did you ever stop to think,
To wonder just exactly what
This does to your beloved tot?
IT ROTS THE SENSE IN THE HEAD!
IT KILLS IMAGINATION DEAD!
IT CLOGS AND CLUTTERS UP THE MIND!
IT MAKES A CHILD SO DULL AND BLIND
HE CAN NO LONGER UNDERSTAND
A FANTASY, A FAIRYLAND!
HIS BRAIN BECOMES AS SOFT AS CHEESE!

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HIS POWERS OF THINKING RUST AND FREEZE!
HE CANNOT THINK -- HE ONLY SEES!
'All right!' you'll cry. 'All right!' you'll say,
'But if we take the set away,
What shall we do to entertain
Our darling children? Please explain!'
We'll answer this by asking you,
'What used the darling ones to do?
'How used they keep themselves contented
Before this monster was invented?'
Have you forgotten? Don't you know?
We'll say it very loud and slow:
THEY ... USED ... TO ... READ! They'd READ and READ,
AND READ and READ, and then proceed
To READ some more. Great Scott! Gadzooks!
One half their lives was reading books!
The nursery shelves held books galore!
Books cluttered up the nursery floor!
And in the bedroom, by the bed,
More books were waiting to be read!
Such wondrous, fine, fantastic tales

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Of dragons, gypsies, queens, and whales
And treasure isles, and distant shores
Where smugglers rowed with muffled oars,
And pirates wearing purple pants,
And sailing ships and elephants,
And cannibals crouching 'round the pot,
Stirring away at something hot.
(It smells so good, what can it be?
Good gracious, it's Penelope.)
The younger ones had Beatrix Potter
With Mr. Tod, the dirty rotter,
And Squirrel Nutkin, Pigling Bland,
And Mrs. Tiggy-Winkle and-
Just How The Camel Got His Hump,
And How the Monkey Lost His Rump,
And Mr. Toad, and bless my soul,
There's Mr. Rate and Mr. Mole-
Oh, books, what books they used to know,
Those children living long ago!
So please, oh please, we beg, we pray,
Go throw your TV set away,

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And in its place you can install
A lovely bookshelf on the wall.
Then fill the shelves with lots of books,
Ignoring all the dirty looks,
The screams and yells, the bites and kicks,
And children hitting you with sticks-
Fear not, because we promise you
That, in about a week or two
Of having nothing else to do,
They'll now begin to feel the need
Of having something to read.
And once they start -- oh boy, oh boy!
You watch the slowly growing joy
That fills their hearts. They'll grow so keen
They'll wonder what they'd ever seen
In that ridiculous machine,
That nauseating, foul, unclean,
Repulsive television screen!
And later, each and every kid
Will love you more for what you did.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Roald Dahl
Book: Charlie and the Chocolate Factory
ISBN: 978-0140328691
Publisher: Puffin
Date(Month/Year): October 1, 1998

AWARDS

2004 National Qualifier
2008 National Qualifier

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